otherwise offend ultra-Orthodox sensibilities. Most times they would be dragged away by police, arrested, occasionally even attacked. A 2013 poll found that a plurality of Israelis—and a narrow majority of Israeli men—supported their campaign, but successive Israeli governments, always fearful of offending the crucial *haredi* parties, made little effort to change policy.

Three years after that survey, though, Israel's most conservative and religious government in decades finally appeared to accede to their demands—in essence by meeting them half way. The wall's main plaza, the iconic 21,500-square-foot backdrop for national ceremonies and visits by foreign dignitaries, would remain segregated and under Orthodox control. But the cabinet established a new mixed-gender area that sits further south, amidst an archaeological site called Robinson's Arch. It is less than half the size of the Orthodox section, and only a narrow portion actually touches the wall, which is largely blocked by piles of millennia-old rubble. The decision was Solomonic. The response was Monty Python: A breakaway group called Original Women of the Wall rejected it, saying they would accept nothing less than full equality.

Still, the Reform rabbis viewed it as a major victory, as they did the high court's ruling on *mikvot*. All strains of Judaism, from Reform to Orthodox, require would-be converts to immerse themselves in a bath. Since the chief rabbinate only recognizes Orthodox conversions, however, the religious services ministry, which oversees the baths, forbade other denominations from using them. The ministry argued in court that non-Orthodox converts could be excluded since they were not legally Jewish. (The court's response was masterful: since no prospective converts are legally Jewish until they finish the process, judges ruled the policy was discriminatory.)

The religious right was furious. One politician, from United Torah Judaism, argued that the supreme court had "no authority to enforce Jewish law." And he singled out the Reform movement for particular criticism. "Not every mentally ill person can come to the operating room, and decide the rules of medicine, and force the hospital to have an operation by whatever way works," said the lawmaker, Israel Eichler. "And so it is intolerable that the directors of ritual baths will have to allow organizers of Reform religion-changing ceremonies into a Jewish ritual bath."[7]

The vitriol continued for weeks, long after the Reform rabbis packed their bags and returned to the United States. David Azoulay, the ultra-